Cheng Chen

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Education

Tongji University Sept. 2023 - Jun. 2027 (expected)
B.Eng. in Communication Engineering, Shanghai, China.
Average score: **92.02/100** GPA: **4.70** Major rank: **2/85**

Main interests

I explore simple, efficient ways to make AI more capable, from learning algorithms to the systems that train and deploy models. My interests span multimodal foundation models, image/video generation, AI infrastructure, and reinforcement learning for embodied agents.

Publications

* Equal contribution; † corresponding author; ‡ project lead.

1) **If You Hear It, Help Find It: Orthogonal Knowledge Distillation for Open-Vocabulary Audio-Visual Event Localization.**
Yi Xu*‡, **Cheng Chen***, Wenzhuo Lei†.
ACM MM 2026, pp. 12794–12802. [PDF] [DOI] [Project]

2) **OrthKD: Extracting Generalized Clinical Knowledge from Heterogeneous Teachers for Lightweight Deployment.**
Yi Xu*†, **Cheng Chen***‡, Mufan Cao.
IJCAI 2026, pp. 6958–6965. [PDF] [DOI] [Code]

3) **Enabling Visual Reasoning in Text-Only LLMs via Symbolic Scene Descriptions.**
Wenzhuo Lei, Mufan Cao, Chaorong Ye, Yi Xu, **Cheng Chen**†‡.
IJCNN 2026, pp. 1–6. [PDF] [DOI]

Research internships

Research Intern
HKUST-GZ Sept. 2026 - Present
Zhejiang University Jun. 2026 - Sept. 2026
Tongji University Oct. 2025 - Jun. 2026

Academic service

Reviewer: ICLR(2027), AAAI(2027), ICME(2026), IJCNN(2026,2027), PRCV(2026).

Research experience

If You Hear It, Help Find It: Orthogonal Knowledge Distillation for Open-Vocabulary Audio-Visual Event Localization *ACM MM 2026; co-first author*

- Routed strong visual supervision to the localization path and weaker audio supervision to an orthogonal auxiliary path; used text prototypes to support unseen event categories.
- Reached **0.816 segment average precision** on OV-AVEBench. F1@0.5 improved over the official fine-tuning baseline by **2.7 points** overall and **3.4 points** on unseen categories.

OrthKD: Extracting Generalized Clinical Knowledge from Heterogeneous Teachers for Lightweight Deployment *IJCAI 2026; co-first author*

- Combined full supervision from a stronger teacher with representation-level transfer from a weaker teacher; orthogonal student projections preserved complementary clinical information.
- Used a combined pool of **132,049** retinal images. A **5.4M**-parameter student reached **0.885 QWK** (quadratic weighted kappa) on EyePACS and improved zero-shot Messidor-2 QWK from **0.507 to 0.728**.

Enabling Visual Reasoning in Text-Only LLMs via Symbolic Scene Descriptions *IJCNN 2026; lead and corresponding author*

- Proposed the initial idea and worked with a junior student, who led implementation and experiments, to connect an object detector with a text-only language model through compact scene reports.
- The pipeline reached **42.3%** visual question answering accuracy on a stratified **5,000-image VQAv2 subset**, versus **38.2%** for scene-graph serialization, using **1/2.5 as many prompt tokens as that baseline**.

Awards and honors

Project Lead

- National First Prize, China Robot and Artificial Intelligence Competition (2026).#
- National Second Prize, Global Campus Artificial Intelligence Algorithm Elite Competition (2025).#
- National Third Prize, National Undergraduate Embedded Chip and System Design Competition (2025).#
- Provincial Second Prize, The Chinese Mathematics Competitions (2024–2025).
- Provincial Third Prize, Contemporary Undergraduate Mathematical Contest in Modeling (2025).#
- Provincial Third Prize, National College Student Statistical Modeling Competition (2025).#
- Tongji University BULL Scholarship (2025–2026; CEIE's highest-tier first-class scholarship).
- Tongji University Outstanding Student Scholarship, Second Class (2023–2024 and 2024–2025).

Technical skills

Programming: Python, C/C++, Verilog.
Machine learning frameworks: PyTorch, JAX.
Tools: Git, Linux, LaTeX, ROS 2, OpenAI Codex, Claude Code.
Foundations: Machine learning, deep learning, algorithms, linear algebra, probability, optimization, and digital signal processing.